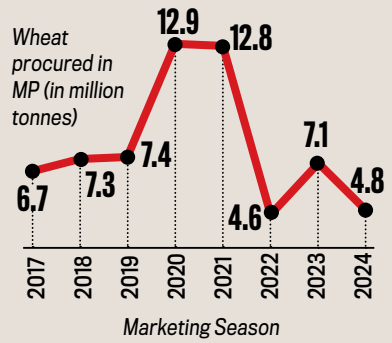


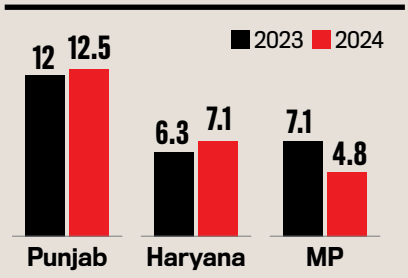
A WORRYING TREND
The total wheat procured in India stood at 26.6 MT on June 16, much lower than the target of 37.3 MT

AFP

LOW OFFTAKE

In 2020, MP was the top wheat procurer in India. Now, both Punjab and Haryana have surpassed it





up affecting the country's food security. As June winds down, the stocks with the Food Corporation of India (FCI) stand at 30.3 MT, just slightly more than the buffer norm of 27.5 MT.

Wheat procurement commenced in some districts on March 15 and spread to the entire state by March 25. The last date for procurement was May 15, but this was extended to May 31 and later all the way to June 25 as procurement failed to pick up. Sources in the government say the extension was announced at the behest of the Centre, which, too, is worried about the buffer stocks. India's total procurement stood at 26.6 MT on June 16, much lower than the target of 37.3 MT for this marketing season. The gap, say experts, is mainly due to the low procurement in Madhya Pradesh.

Even agriculture experts are racking their heads to come up with a reason for the sluggishness. On the official side, they are citing the erratic weather during the crop cycle to paint a picture of less-than-bountiful farms. "There has been a drop in production due to unseasonal rains during harvest season and extreme heat conditions in the period before harvesting," says Ravindra Singh, the state's food and civil supplies commissioner. Officials also hint at an entirely different track, which would seem incompatible with the one above. Private sector procurement via *mandis*, they say, has been higher this year compared to previous seasons. Higher prices were on offer here for better quality wheat than what the government was offering. Consequently, a considerable quantity of the wheat available went the private sector players' way. "Farmers who can afford to do so are also holding stock in the hope that prices will rise further post monsoon," adds Singh.

EXPERTS REFUSE TO BUY THE OFFICIAL LINE THAT CITES A DIP IN PRODUCTION. THE STATE'S HIGH MSP, INSTEAD, SEEMS TO BE PROVING AN UNSTATED BURDEN

Independent experts are refusing to buy the official line of lower production as an adequate explanation. Dr J.B. Singh, head of the Indore regional centre of the Indian Agricultural Research Institute (IARI), acknowledges some decline but not on a scale that could reflect in plummeting procurement. "A round of rain in late September and early October last year made farmers sow in October. This was followed by a period of high temperatures, which prevented tillering—leading to a drop in production," he says. "But the drop would only be around 4-5 per cent. Not substantial."

Wheat has been one of Madhya Pradesh's success stories in recent decades. The state now produces 23-24 MT of wheat, the highest after Uttar Pradesh, where production surpassed 34 MT in the 2022-23 rabi season. Productivity in Madhya Pradesh is in line with the national average: 34 quintals per hectare. Off the record, officials speak of stringent quality norms being enforced, and that contributing to the depleted offtake. Government buying centres are said to be rejecting discoloured grain,